The Mom Test — Cheatsheet

Based on Rob Fitzpatrick's "The Mom Test" · themomtest.com

The One Rule

Talk about their life, not your idea. People will lie to you — not because they're bad, but because they're polite. Your job is to make it impossible for them to lie.

The 5 Rules

1. Talk about their life, not your idea

- Bad: "Would you use an app that does X?"
- Good: "How do you currently handle X? Walk me through the last time."

2. Ask about specifics in the past, not hypotheticals about the future

- Bad: "Would you pay $10/month for this?"
- Good: "What did you spend on solving this last month? Show me the receipt."

3. Talk less, listen more

- If you're talking more than 30% of the time, you're pitching, not learning.

4. Seek commitment and advancement

- Words are cheap. Ask for something: time, money, reputation, or access.
- "Can I follow you while you do this next Tuesday?" > "Sounds interesting!"

5. Push for specifics on compliments and fluff

- When they say "That's a great idea!" → ask: "When was the last time you tried to solve this?"

- When they say “I’d definitely use that!” → ask: “Can you show me your current workaround?”

The Conversation Flow

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1. CONTEXT    → "What does your day look like when you deal with [problem area]?"
2. PAIN       → "What's the hardest part about that?"
3. FREQUENCY  → "How often does this come up?"
4. STAKES     → "What happens when it goes wrong?"
5. CURRENT    → "What do you do about it now? How much does that cost you?"
6. COMMITMENT → "Would you be willing to [specific next step] this week?"
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Red Flags (You’re Doing It Wrong)

You hear…	It means…
“That’s a great idea!”	They’re being polite. You pitched instead of asked.
“I would definitely use that”	Future tense = fantasy. Ask about the past.
“I’d pay $X for that”	Hypothetical money isn’t real. Ask for a pre-order.
Everyone says yes	Your questions are leading. Flip the script.
No one mentions the problem unprompted	The problem might not be real.

Green Flags (You’re Learning Something Real)

You observe…	It means…
They describe specific workarounds	The problem is real and painful enough to act on
They’ve already spent money on alternatives	Willingness to pay is proven
They lean forward, get emotional, share details	You’ve hit a nerve — dig deeper
They offer to introduce you to others with the problem	Social proof + distribution channel
They ask when they can use it	Pull > Push

After Each Conversation

Write down exactly 3 things:

1. **What did I learn that I didn’t know before?**
2. **What assumption was confirmed or destroyed?**
3. **What’s the next riskiest assumption I need to test?**

If you can’t answer these, the conversation was wasted.